Instead of asking why the Special Branch carried out such a shoddy investigation, we start doubting the innocence of a ‘blameless citizen’ who has been victimized by a ‘corrupt and communal’ police and a ‘prejudiced’ designated judge.

Let us examine the facts relating to the actual attack that have emerged in the course of the trial of the four accused in the Parliament attack case, facts that the media has refused to publish, facts that raise uncomfortable questions that must be answered if we want to protect Indian democracy.

At first the government told us that the attack was the handiwork of the Lashkar-e-Toiba and Jaish-e- Mohammad and that the five attackers were Pakistanis. L.K. Advani, our home minister at the time, announced in Parliament that they ‘looked Pakistani’. However, in the course of the trial, not one of the prosecution’s eighty witnesses ever alleged that any of the four accused belonged to any terrorist organization. Even the designated court was hard put to find a way of convicting the accused of belonging to any terrorist organization. As for the five men who actually attacked the Parliament, the only ‘evidence’ that they were Pakistanis was that no Indian came forward to claim their bodies.

The main accused, Mohammad Afzal [who has, since this essay first appeared, been sentenced to death by the supreme court, and whose clemency petition lies with the President of India], is a self-confessed surrendered militant—a renegade in the eyes of militants. Besides, he is a surrendered militant of the JKLF, a group that has already laid down arms. Why would a Pakistan-based militant organization trust a renegade, that too of the JKLF, with such an important job? Especially when the man had been working in Delhi for the past ten years and his entire motivation seemed to have been money.

Afzal has admitted to playing an inadvertant peripheral role in the conspiracy. He said he brought one of the attackers, Mohammad, from the Special Task Force (STF) camp. However, he also insisted that he did not know the other four attackers who were killed during the attack. If he can be sentenced to death on three counts on the basis of his own confession, why can we not believe the other part of his story recorded in the court under Section 313 of the Criminal Procedure Code?

We must demand that the government table a full report on the facts relating to the attack on Parliament. We have a right to know who actually attacked our Parliament. Why have we not made this demand? Out of a sense